

The issue with ai's water consumption

Posted by u/JooshOC- • 0 points • 18 comments

Could someone explain what the big deal is? Isn't water a very abundant resource that even if used will just return to the earth? I'd appreciate if you could link some credible sources that discuss the environmental effect of it as well, for some reason I'm having a hard time finding this info. Which is strange considering how so many people bring it up. I have an idea of the issue, I just struggle to see it as being on a large enough scale to overshadow its other problems

Comments

u/WatchAndFern • 1 points • 2026-03-14 21:11 UTC

It's not specifically about AI, but water is definitely not an abundant resource that is returning to earth as a renewable source.

Currently three quarters of the world experience water insecurity and this has been rapidly increasing over the past three decades.

This report again is not specifically about AI but addresses the reality that most of the world does not have the water it needs

<https://unu.edu/inweh/news/world-enters-era-of-global-water-bankruptcy>

In terms of AI, it's similar to the arguments about energy consumption. We are living in a time where we need to be reducing our consumption, or be very considerate of how we use our resources, to avoid catastrophe. AI is definitely not the only contributor to this scarcity, but it is a contributor, a new contributor and for critics of AI, if we're entering a world where we are questioning what sort of farming we should do to avoid water loss, people question if AI is worth it.

u/Silly_Goose6714 • 2 points • 2026-03-13 15:17 UTC

People opposed to AI need more people for activism, so they want to recruit environmental activists.

u/2008knight • 1 points • 2026-03-13 11:52 UTC

Water is very abundant on earth, but most of it is salt water. Fresh water is much less common and reservoirs are quickly depleting.

Sure, AI isn't the major driver of fresh water depletion it's being depicted as, but there has been water scarcity fears for many years, so it is a very easy vector of attack.

u/kojimbob • 2 points • 2026-03-13 11:33 UTC

![gif](giphy|aQHQQZ2KRUBATrCfZMd)

u/Human_certified • 6 points • 2026-03-13 10:22 UTC

Not really. Data centers use a few hundred billion liters a year, out of the several million billion (not a typo) humanity uses as a whole. They also don't pollute.

Local issues can be something else though. If you build a datacenter in Arizona on top of a distressed aquifer, yeah, don't do that. Also don't build golf courses there.

Just read this: <https://andymasley.substack.com/p/the-ai-water-issue-is-fake>

The author is very much engaged with the climate and environment, not a datacenter apologist.

u/Puzzleheaded-Rope808 • 1 points • 2026-03-13 10:18 UTC

All modern datacenters use closed loop propylene glycol D2C (direct to chip) technology almost without exception as it is 100x more efficient and costworthy. More water is used in their employee bathrooms.

the reason why you cannot find that data is it is incorrect. It's based on a 5 year old study by MIT before the technology came out.

But for arguments sake, let's go back 5 years. Datacenters used water to pour over the hot plates of heat exchangers in their evaporative coolers. It turned to steam, which then turned to clouds, which then turned to rain. No chemicals were introduced. Nothing was contaminated. The issue is that one plant early on drained an aquifer. That was 1999. They use greywater now, so even that argument died years ago.

u/pwnedinthepnw • 1 points • 2026-03-13 09:16 UTC

Water is renewable. However, as with electricity, we can't all use it simultaneously. Probably in your experience you've never gone without clean drinking water, so think instead of one household sharing a water heater. Hot water gets used, the tank is replenished, more water is heated, again and again. Not a problem when rationing out the usage over time. But if everybody wants to take a hot shower all at once? Cue angry fighting. You might have multiple bathrooms, one for each person, but the hot water tank holds only so many gallons. And say one housemate loves long steamy showers morning and evening, every single day. Even if everyone else is quick and efficient, the fact is the "hot" water is now lukewarm if not downright cold. Imagine that daily impact. You'd be upset.

Let's say the shower-enjoyer is willing to compromise and, instead of hour-long showers twice a day, decides to take a bath. Great! That's comparatively less water than the previous amount, and they only need to top off every now and then. Maybe you'd even accept that, from a housemate you already know. Subsidize a little luxury to stay on good terms, why not. But you wouldn't want to for a bunch more new people moving in.

If data centers could drink non-potable water, that would be amazing, if we didn't have to compete. As is, they heavily divert resources, and the increased demand raises costs for locals who don't see the benefit. Arguably, while we all pay into things we'd all rather not, directly or otherwise, many people feel that "AI" is too frivolous to be one of them. (Some people feel the same about golf courses. I agree! For multiple reasons. Even if golf were free and open to the public, fertilizer run-off is bad.) Like taxpayers funding stadiums as a shared burden, yet it's the owner class taking advantage. Ideally we could still enjoy the fun for what it is, but corporations are pushing AI so hard, spreading the gimmick everywhere, that it's started to feel more than a little cancerous. Too much of a good thing, so to speak. And not even that good, depending on who you ask.

u/Latimas • 3 points • 2026-03-13 08:39 UTC

[https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=H_c6MWk7PQc](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=H_c6MWk7PQc) this is the best video on the topic. there is nuance

u/Puzzleheaded-Rope808 • 1 points • 2026-03-13 10:14 UTC

Yes, because getting news from a dude wearing a flannel shirt in a basement using 4 year old data is trustworthy, right?

Cool story. Do anti-vax and ufo sightings next 🤔

u/Latimas • 2 points • 2026-03-13 10:25 UTC

"wearing a flannel shirt" what's your point here? are people wearing flannel shirts notoriously untrustworthy or something?

"in a basement" what are you basing that claim on? what's the problem even if he is in a basement? what is inherently negative about being in a basement that invalidates your points?

"using 4 year old data" you will need to prove that, please.

u/Puzzleheaded-Rope808 • 3 points • 2026-03-13 11:26 UTC

Is he not wearing a flannel shirt? Are you SERIOUSLY defending some random dude on YouTube? Just watch Fox News or Newsmax if you wanna go the unreliable source. Even they might be more trustworthy.

No. No I do not need to prove it. If you can't read dates or are too ignorant to keep up with current technology like normal people do, then that's on you.

u/Used_Lobster4172 • 5 points • 2026-03-13 13:27 UTC

Hank Green is not just "some random dude on YouTube." He is one of the current major science communicators. His content is used in classrooms all over the world, he has partnered with universities and more. If you truly believe he is just "some random dude on YouTube" you should probably actually do some research.

u/Latimas • 1 points • 2026-03-13 14:34 UTC

thank you

u/Puzzleheaded-Rope808 • 3 points • 2026-03-13 14:05 UTC

LoI, no. No itbis not. He's a stand up comedian. He has no relevant education and its a moot point as his information is based on 4 year old technology.

Look, you've got to be a total idiot to believe anything you see on a channel designed to get likes to get paid. Engaging content majes money. That's like "duh" 101

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2026-03-13 14:33 UTC

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u/Used_Lobster4172 • 2 points • 2026-03-13 14:28 UTC

You can say any words you like but that doesn't make them reality. Pretending he isn't a science communicator is just that, you pretending.

u/[deleted]

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2026-03-13 14:35 UTC

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u/Latimas • 1 points • 2026-03-13 13:26 UTC

ngl just ask chatgpt to present me with an argument. Even that's better than this nothing burger of a reply "I do not need to back up my claim". You're certainly a less trustworthy source than this random dude on YouTube, who actually backs up what he says—so I'll listen to him first until you, a random dude on reddit, give me reasoning

u/LerytGames • 5 points • 2026-03-13 08:25 UTC

There is no real issue. Modern datacenters are using closed loop cooling. So water is pumped once in, and then there may be some more consumption because of maintenance or issues with leaks. Real daily water usage is mainly by employees in kitchens, drinking, toilets, etc. And cleaning services - it's huge buildings.

u/colexian • 2 points • 2026-03-13 08:46 UTC

A huge amount, more than half of all water consumption globally, is used for agriculture. Then industrial use, municipal use, and energy production (Which is where I think the AI stuff is more of a concern than direct water usage, if I understand that side's argument correctly.) As well, a large non-trival amount goes towards construction (largely concrete).